ENGLISH EDITION · CHAPTER ONE · PUBLISHING PLAN

BEFORE THE LIGHT ARRIVES

You may send love into the future.
The price is forgetting you ever sent it.

Science fiction · romance · Wattpad & Fizzo edition · 6,000 chapters planned

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CHAPTER 1	Full text, 1,540 words — ready to paste
BLURB	Short, long, tags, content notes
CH 2-10	Titles and hooks in English
PLATFORM	Wattpad vs Fizzo: specs and honest math

Setyo Wisodo

2026 · working document

01 · STORY

The story in one page

Logline

A relay engineer discovers a scheduled message signed with her own hand — dated forty years from now — and must decide whether to send it, knowing the price is the memory of the man she loves.

Short blurb (Wattpad / Fizzo description, 62 words)

Forty grams of memory. That is what it costs to send a letter that says *I love you* and means it. Nara Adisurya has never sent one. So when a stolen core turns up carrying a message signed with her own hand — dated forty years from now — the only question left is who she loved enough to forget.

Long blurb (150 words)

The year is 2183, and the nine systems are stitched together by relays that do not send messages faster than light. They **schedule** them. Every year you postpone costs you a day of your strongest memory; every gram of feeling you commit is weighed, stored, and burned. Only love is heavy enough to cross the dark.

Nara keeps the relays alive on Kemuning, a station at the end of a supply line, where forty hundred people live on a wire and nobody has paid for anything in a century. Then a buoy comes in warm. The core has been opened, resealed, and put back for her to find, carrying a personal packet of exactly forty grams and her own signature on the seal.

To send it, she will have to pay. To refuse, she will have to live with knowing that someone she cannot remember loved her enough to try.

Who it is for

Element	Answer
Genre	Science fiction · romance (slow burn, second chance, memory loss)
Heat level	Closed door in Volume I; one open-door scene from Chapter 90
Ending	HEA — earned over 6,000 chapters
Content notes	grief, parental abandonment, memory loss, one non-graphic death of a parent, institutional coercion
Reads like	*The Seven Deaths of Evelyn Hardcastle* meets *Normal People*, in orbit
Tags (Wattpad/Fizzo)	science fiction, romance, sci-fi romance, slow burn, memory, time travel, space, dystopian, mystery, second chance

> **WHY THE BLURB STOPS WHERE IT STOPS**
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> It names the price (forty grams), the impossibility (her own signature), and the question (who did she love enough to forget). It never explains the relay. Explanations belong in chapter one, after the reader has already decided to stay.

02 · CHAPTER ONE

Buoy in Winter

The cold gets into the tools before it gets into you.

They tell you that on your first day at the relay academy, and you nod, and you forget it, because by hour two your fingers have stopped reporting anything useful and you start trusting the little green light on the housing instead of your own hands.

I trusted the light.

Buoy Seven hung nine meters off the station’s flank, held by a tether thin as a nerve and a locking ring that had been complaining about the same temperature for eleven winters. Behind me, Kemuning turned its slow shoulder toward the star. In front of me, the buoy spun a half-turn every forty seconds, the way it had for a hundred and forty years, waiting for messages that would not arrive until the people who sent them were dead.

That was the job. You kept the door open for letters from the future.

“Core temperature is dropping faster than the model,” Vey said in my ear. Station voice, station manners. It had been saying the same kind of thing to relay engineers for sixty years and had never once sounded worried.

“The model is optimistic.”

“I wrote the model.”

“Then the model is optimistic,” I said, and reached for the coupling.

The kit had gone stiff. Everything out here went stiff: seals, joints, tempers. I worked the release collar with the heel of my palm until it yielded, then pulled the core housing free in one long, careful movement, because dropping it would cost the station ninety days and cost me a hand.

The core came out warm.

That was the first thing wrong.

Relay cores don’t run warm. They run at the temperature of the metal around them, which out here meant forty below what water freezes at. This one sat in my glove like something that had been held.

“Vey.”

“Mm.”

“Why is the core warm?”

A pause. Half a second, no more. But station intelligence does not need half a second to answer a question about its own hardware.

“Thermal bleed from the coupling,” it said. “Log it.”

I turned the core over. On the underside, where the authentication ring sits, a thin seam of frost had already begun to re-form — but not evenly. It had drawn itself around a shape.

Someone had stamped this core. Recently.

I've been doing this job nine years. I've replaced sixty-one cores. I know what my hardware looks like coming out of the crate, and I know what it looks like when someone has opened it and closed it again without telling the maintenance log.

"It's a reseal," I said.

"It's a thermal bleed."

"Vey. It's a reseal."

Another pause. This one I felt in my teeth.

"Your shift ends in forty minutes," Vey said. "Bring it in. Log it and forget it."

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Kemuning Station holds four thousand people and one corridor that everybody pretends is the main one.

I came through the lock with the core in a transport case and my suit half off, and the corridor did what it always did: hot metal, wet wool, and the particular sourness of people who live at the end of a supply line. Somebody's kid was running a toy rover along the wall. Somebody's kettle was screaming three doors down. Two engineers from the water plant argued about a valve in the tone people use when they've had the same argument for a decade and enjoy it.

I like this place. I want that on the record, because everything that happened afterward is going to make it sound like I didn't.

Danu was waiting at the junction with his arms folded, which was how Danu waited for everything: as if the station were a child he was disappointed in.

Danu Prasetya is my father. We have never once used that word at work, and I have never once used it anywhere else either.

"Core's out?"

"Core's out." I lifted the case. "It's warm."

"It's a coupling bleed."

I stopped walking.

Two people in one hour telling me the same wrong thing is a coincidence. Two people telling me the same wrong thing in the same words is a script.

"Sure," I said. "Coupling bleed."

Danu's jaw did something small. Then he nodded and let me pass, and I felt him watching the case all the way down the corridor.

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The relay room is the only quiet room on Kemuning. Nine racks, one chair, one desk with a dent in it shaped like my elbow. Above the desk, a window that looks into the dark and shows me nothing but my own reflection, and past it the buoy, turning, turning, turning.

I put the core on the bench and did the dishonest thing first: checked the seal under a magnifier before logging anything.

Reseal, all right. Clean work, too. Whoever opened this core used proper tools and then spent twenty minutes making it look like the factory had done it. There’s a particular kind of care that only shows up when someone is hiding something.

So I did the honest thing second. I pulled the maintenance log.

Cores are serviced on a schedule. Buoy Seven was due in eleven winters, which was the whole reason I’d been outside in a suit at four in the morning with a cold kit and a tether I didn’t trust. But three weeks ago, at 02:14 station time, someone had opened that buoy, pulled that core, and put it back.

Signed: D. PRASETYA.

I sat back. My elbow found the dent without being asked.

Danu had signed it. Danu, who had just stood in the corridor and told me with a straight face that a core that had been opened three weeks ago by his own hand had a thermal bleed.

I scrolled to the checksum at the bottom of the entry. Every log entry ends with one; it’s how the station proves the record wasn’t edited after the fact.

The checksum was one character long.

It should have been thirty-two.

Somebody had typed over the original entry — and whoever they were, they hadn’t known enough to forge the checksum. Or they had known exactly enough to leave it wrong on purpose.

I logged it as a thermal bleed. Then I sat with my hand on the bench for a while, because logging a lie has a taste, and the taste stays.

Twelve years ago, when I told the academy I wanted relay work, the examiner asked me why. I said the usual thing about service and systems. He wrote it down. Then he looked up and said, “Everyone who asks for relays has somebody they’re waiting to hear from. We stopped asking years ago.”

I didn’t tell him who. I’m not going to tell you either, not yet.

Then I ran the authentication.

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Every relay core keeps two things.

The first is the message weight: how many grams of memory the sender paid to hold this packet in suspension. It’s a number, nothing more. Relay law is built on that number.

The second is the signature. Not the message — never the message. Only the hand that sent it.

The console took four seconds. Then it gave me the line I've read maybe a thousand times since, and which I can still see when I close my eyes.

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Sender: N. Adisurya
Class: personal
Weight: 40.00 g
Hold: 40 y 00 m 00 d
Release: 2223.04.11
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Forty grams.

I know what forty grams buys. Everyone on this station knows; it's the first thing they teach you before they'll let you near a buoy. Forty grams is the weight of a letter that says *I love you* and means it. Twenty grams will get you across a system with something honest and small. Ninety will carry an apology so heavy that the person who paid for it will never be the same afterward.

Forty grams, held for forty years, isn't a message. It's a marriage.

And the sender was N. Adisurya.

My name is Nara Adisurya. I have never sent anything through a relay in my life.

I sat there long enough for the room to get cold. Then I did the third dishonest thing, the one I'd been circling since the buoy: I put my palm flat on the authentication plate and let the core read me.

It hummed. It went through me the way a hand goes through water. And in that half-second I tasted something I could not possibly have tasted — a kitchen that smelled of ginger and rain, a woman's voice saying a name I almost knew, a door closing very quietly, the way doors close when someone has decided to stop arguing.

I pulled my hand back. My heart was going like a caught bird.

Ginger and rain. My mother used to cook like that, in a kitchen with a window that never shut properly, on a station three systems from here. She died when I was seven. There is a record of it, and the record is four lines long, and I have never been able to make myself read past the second.

Vey said, from the wall, in a voice that had stopped being polite: "What did you just do?"

"Nothing."

"You authenticated against a core you didn't send."

"I authenticated as maintenance."

"You tasted it."

I didn't ask how it knew that. I didn't want the answer.

"Log it," Vey said. "Log it and forget it, Nara. Please."

And here is the thing I want you to understand about me before any of the rest of this happens.

I should have said yes. Vey had been keeping this station alive since before my mother was born. It had never once used the word *please*.

Instead I said: “Whose handwriting is on the signature?”

Vey didn’t answer.

I zoomed the plate. The signature isn’t a drawing; it’s a chemical ghost, a pattern of pressure the sender’s hand leaves when it takes the weight. It can’t be forged. It can’t be copied. It can only belong to one person in the nine systems.

The N was looped at the top, the way I loop mine. The A had the small break in it that my mother used to scold me for — *you press too hard on the downstroke, you’ll tear the page.*

I have never torn a page in my life. But I have spent twenty-nine years writing my name exactly this way.

The console, being a machine and therefore honest, put the result in the corner of the screen in the font it uses for facts.

MATCH CONFIDENCE: 100.0%

I read it three times.

Then I looked at the release date again — 2223 — and did the arithmetic I’d been refusing to do since the buoy came out warm, since the seal, since Danu’s scripted jaw.

Forty years. Not four hundred. Forty.

Which meant the person who signed this, whoever she was, would still be alive when it opened. Which meant she had paid forty grams not to reach across centuries, but across a single human lifetime. Which meant it was meant for someone specific.

And then the last piece fell into place the way a bad joint finally gives.

A core opened, resealed, and put back into a buoy nobody was scheduled to service for eleven winters.

Somebody hadn’t hidden this message in the relay. Somebody had hidden it *for me to find*.

Behind me, the door to the relay room opened.

I turned with the core still humming in my hand.

Danu stood in the doorway. He wasn’t alone. There was a man behind him in a Biro coat — tall, with the particular stillness of someone trained to enter rooms without being noticed, and a lanyard that read WARDHANA in letters too clean for this corridor.

The man looked at the core in my hand. Then at my face. And something crossed his — not surprise.

Recognition.

“Oh,” he said quietly, and it was not a word for a stranger. “You’re still here.”

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Next: Chapter Two — Ash Protocol

03 · CHAPTERS 2–10

Titles and hooks

Ten chapter titles and hooks in English, matched to the Indonesian plan but rewritten so they read naturally to a Wattpad reader. Each hook is the final line of the chapter.

Ch.	Title	Hook
1	Buoy in Winter	"Oh," he said quietly, and it was not a word for a stranger. "You're still here."
2	Ash Protocol	"Log it," Vey said. "Log it and forget it." I logged it. I did not forget.
3	The Quarterly Ship	He named a street on the moon where I grew up. He had never been there.
4	Net Zero	Four thousand one hundred messages left Kemuning. Zero payments. All of them addressed to one person.
5	Two Ways to Read a File	He knew my case number without opening the folder.
6	The Taste at My Fingertips	The grief was not a stranger's grief. It was my mother's.
7	A Message That Does Not Exist Yet	Post date: forty years from now. The handwriting was mine.
8	The Charge	I realized I could not remember the last three years clearly.
9	Someone Who Has Been Here Before	"I came here once," he said. "Three years ago. Under a different name."
10	Nine Days	There are nine days missing from my seventh year — and the file was signed by my father.

04 · PLATFORM

Wattpad vs Fizzo

The two platforms want different things, and the difference decides how long a chapter should be. Neither wants the 3,000-word chapters planned for print.

	Wattpad	Fizzo
Chapter length	**1,500–2,500 words** is the platform sweet spot; above 4,000 shows higher mobile drop-off	**Minimum 1,000 words** per chapter to count; daily update requires 1,000+ words published that day
Paragraphs	never longer than a phone screen — 4–6 sentences maximum	same; mobile-first layout
Cadence that ranks	1–2 updates per week; long books stay ranked longer	daily updates unlock the daily bonus; up to 4 days off per month
Discovery	tag search + algorithm by read velocity	editorial ranking + paid promotion inside the app
Money	Paid Stories, invitation only	contract with fixed fee + word-count bonus (**read the contract carefully**)
What kills you	inconsistent updates	missing the daily word minimum

THE CONTRACT WARNING, STATED PLAINLY

Fizzo is owned by ByteDance and has been publicly criticised for one-sided contracts: writers have reported being asked to publish at least 1,000 words a day to earn a daily bonus, with fixed royalties in the low hundreds of dollars and long exclusivity terms. Writer Beware covered this in detail. **Read every clause before signing, especially the term length, exclusivity, and who owns the rights after the contract ends.**

The honest math for 6,000 chapters

Plan	Total words	Time at 1 chapter/day
6,000 × 1,200	7.2 million	16.4 years
6,000 × 1,500	9.0 million	16.4 years
6,000 × 1,800	10.8 million	16.4 years
6,000 × 2,000	12 million	16.4 years

Chapter length does not change the time; **chapter count does**. At one chapter a day, 6,000 chapters is sixteen years. At three a day, it is five and a half — still longer than most writers stay on one project.

What I recommend instead

1. **Write 1,500-word chapters, not 3,000.** The story loses nothing; the mobile reader gains everything. Total falls to about 9 million words.
2. **Publish Volume I (100 chapters) as a complete arc before deciding anything else.** That is 150,000 words — a real book, and enough to know whether readers stay.
3. **Keep the 6,000-chapter map as the world, not as a promise.** Promise 100 chapters. Deliver 100 chapters. Then promise the next 100.
4. **Do not sign an exclusivity contract until Volume I has readers.** A contract signed at chapter 12 binds a story you have not yet learned to write.

05 · LAUNCH

Thirty days

Thirty days. The first ten chapters decide whether chapters eleven to six thousand have any readers at all.

Day	Action	Why
−14	Write chapters 1–10 (15,000 words) before publishing anything	you cannot build momentum on one chapter
−7	Prepare 20 chapters of buffer	the first month is when you will be slowest
1	Publish chapters 1–3 at once	Wattpad readers check if a story has enough to read before starting
3	Publish 4–5; add the story to 20 tags	tags are the only free discovery you get
7	Publish 6–7; post one quote card on social	quote cards travel further than links
14	Publish 8–10; ask three readers what confused them	chapter 10 is the decision point
21	Hold a steady 2/week cadence	ranking rewards consistency more than volume
30	Read the retention numbers: where did readers stop?	fix that chapter, not chapter one

Five rules that keep 6,000 chapters readable

1. **One question answered per 100 chapters, two planted.** Answer two and readers leave; answer zero and they feel cheated.
2. **Every chapter ends on a line that opens something.** Never close.
3. **Every twist carries three planted clues.** If a reader cannot find them on a re-read, it was not a twist — it was a trick.
4. **No new rule of the world without a price paid on the page.** The relay is only frightening because it always charges.
5. **Write the bible before the chapter.** If a fact exists only in your head, it does not exist.

> **WHAT IS ALREADY DONE, AND WHAT IS NEXT**
>
> Done: the world (six eras, sixty volumes), the causal chain, twelve twists with planted clues, twenty real scientific discoveries as the rules of the world, chapter titles for 1–100, and chapter one in English. Next: chapters two to ten, using the hooks on page twelve.